

Agenda & Objectives

Food Assistance Strategic Dialogue: Advancing Evidence and Research Priorities for Food Security and Nutrition Outcomes in Humanitarian Settings

14-15 May 2026 | Johns Hopkins Bloomberg Center
555 Pennsylvania Avenue NW, Washington, D.C., United States of America

Meeting Background

Humanitarian food assistance is entering a period of profound policy and financing transition. While lifesaving food assistance in humanitarian settings remains indispensable, the resources that sustain the evidence base behind it—research, monitoring, evaluation, and technical learning—are under increasing strain. This creates a critical risk: without targeted investment in the systems that identify what works, improve implementation, and ensure accountability, food assistance programs will be less able to deliver strong nutrition and food security outcomes in an increasingly constrained environment.

For this one and one-half day event, the Johns Hopkins Bloomberg School of Public Health and Jhpiego have brought together a high-level, action-oriented group spanning academic and research institutions, UN agencies, non-government organizations, and policy actors to discuss opportunities to safeguard past gains, sharpen priority-setting for the future, and catalyze a practical research agenda that keeps food assistance effective and accountable.

Meeting Objectives

1. **Align global stakeholders** around the most urgent research, monitoring, and evaluation priorities for humanitarian food assistance, including in-kind assistance, cash-based assistance, and specialized nutritious foods, to improve food security and nutrition outcomes.
2. **Build consensus on the most critical evidence gaps** facing humanitarian food assistance in the current context.
3. **Set clear priorities for action across key areas** such as implementation and operational research, and stronger monitoring systems, with a focus on the most strategic food assistance approaches in a constrained funding environment.
4. **Define a focused agenda** of priority sub-topics and research questions to guide near-term evidence generation, and decision-making.

Day 1 Thursday, 14 May

Start Time	Topic / Activity	Speaker / Facilitator
8:30 AM	Registration & Refreshments	
Session 1: Setting the Scene <i>Moderators: S. Walton (JHBSPH) and E. Keats (JHBSPH)</i>		
9:00 AM	Welcome & Introductions	Session Moderators
9:30 AM	History of Humanitarian Food Assistance & Research	S. Doocy (JHBSPH) M. Bloem (JHBSPH)
9:45 AM	Setting the Stage: Policy, Financing, and Programmatic Shifts in Humanitarian Food Assistance	J. Canahuati (Independent), Moderator S. DePee (WFP) – remote A. Narayan (UNICEF) M. Joy (CARE) J. Vanyur (Helen Keller Intl)
10:45 AM	MORNING BREAK	
Session 2: Data Innovations <i>Moderators H. Tappis (Jhpiego)</i>		
11:00 AM	Funding Cuts and Health and Nutrition Data: Impacts, Concerns and Considerations	C. Altare (JHBSPH)
11:10 AM	Early Warning in an Age of Scarcity: Reimagining Evidence for Humanitarian Food Assistance	T. Boudreau (FEWS NET)
11:20 AM	Tracking Aid Allocation Against Humanitarian Need: AI-Powered Data Infrastructure for Accountability and Gap Analysis	C. Kim (JHBSPH)
11:30 AM	Data Systems Under Funding Pressure: Implications for decision-making and priorities for action	M. Woldt (Independent)
11:40 AM	Panel Discussion and Q&A	Session Moderator
Session 3: Sharing the Current Evidence <i>Moderators: S. Walton (JHBSPH) and E. Keats (JHBSPH)</i>		
11:55 AM	Framing the Session	Session Moderators

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Start Time	Topic / Activity	Speaker / Facilitator
12:00 PM	Evidence Methods and Survey Results	G. Varela (JHBSPH) Z. Zimme (JHBSPH)
Evidence Session A: Food Assistance and Food Security Outcomes <i>Moderator: S. Doocy (JHBSPH)</i>		
12:15 PM	Framing and Overview – Food Security Outcomes	Session Moderator
12:25 PM	Additional Evidence and Current Priorities	A. Seal (UCL) – remote
12:35 PM	The Impact of Humanitarian Aid Cuts/Delays on Welfare of IDPs: Evidence from Sudan	K. Abay (IFPRI)
12:45 PM	Q&A	Session Moderator
Evidence Session B: Food Assistance and Child Nutrition Outcomes <i>Moderator: B. Rogers (Tufts)</i>		
12:55 PM	Framing and Overview – Child Nutrition Outcomes	Session Moderator
1:05 PM	Additional Evidence and Current Priorities	H. Stobaugh (AAH)
1:15 PM	Simplifying the Treatment of Acute Malnutrition: A Decade of Evidence at the International Rescue Committee	J. Bailey (IRC)
1:25 PM	Q&A	Session Moderator
1:35 PM	LUNCH BREAK	
Evidence Session C: Food Assistance and School-Aged Children and Adolescent Outcomes <i>Moderator: M. Bloem (JHBSPH)</i>		
2:35 PM	Framing and Overview – School-Aged Children & Adolescents	Session Moderator
2:45 PM	Additional Evidence and Current Priorities	A. Gelli (IFPRI)
2:55 PM	Nutrition programming for school-age children and adolescents in humanitarian contexts: a guidance and evidence review	N. Lelijveld (ENN)
3:05 PM	Q&A	Session Moderator

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Start Time	Topic / Activity	Speaker / Facilitator
Evidence Session D: Food Assistance and Maternal Nutrition Outcomes <i>Moderator: A. Thorne-Lyman (JHBSPH)</i>		
3:15 PM	Framing and Overview – Maternal Nutrition Outcomes	Session Moderator
3:25 PM	Additional Evidence and Current Priorities	P. James (ENN)
3:35 PM	Tools for preventing and improving care of malnourished infants under 6 months	M. Mwangome (KEMRI Wellcome Trust)
3:45 PM	Q&A	Session Moderator
Session 4: Research Gaps		
4:20 PM	Breakout Group Discussion	JHBSPH Facilitators: E. Keats, E. Wilkinson, G. Reiss, G. Varela, R. Auer, S. Walton, Z. Zimme
5:05 PM	Report Back	Group reporters
5:25 PM	Day 1 Wrap-Up & Preview of Day 2	E. Keats (JHBSPH) S. Walton (JHBSPH)
5:45 PM	DAY 1 Adjourned	

Day 2 Friday, 15 May

Start Time	Topic / Activity	Speaker / Facilitator
8:30 AM	Registration & Refreshments	
9:00 AM	Day 2 Welcome & Recap of Day 1	E. Keats (JHBSPH) S. Walton (JHBSPH)

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Start Time	Topic / Activity	Speaker / Facilitator
Session 5: Interview Spotlight – Adaptive Programs, Actionable Evidence Moderator: R. Klemm (Helen Keller Intl / JHBSPH)		
9:25 AM	Interviews: How Teams Generated Evidence Under Constrained Resources	M. Alemu (CRS) D. Moyer (Concern Worldwide) C. Antoine (Action Against Hunger)
10:00 AM	Q&A	Session Moderator
Session 6: Research Prioritization Moderators: S. Walton (JHBSPH) and E. Keats (JHBSPH)		
10:10 AM	Explanation of Prioritization Exercise	E. Keats (JHBSPH) R. Auer (JHBSPH) S. Walton (JHBSPH)
10:20 AM	Prioritization Exercise	JHBSPH Facilitators: E. Keats, E. Wilkinson, G. Reiss, G. Varela, R. Auer, S. Walton, Z. Zimme
10:50 AM	Share Out	Session Moderators
11:05 AM	MORNING BREAK	
Session 7: Policy, Programming, & Advocacy Moderator: Patrick Webb (Tufts)		
11:25 AM	Policy, Advocacy & Research – What Needs to Happen Next?	S.DePee (WFP) – remote B. Rogers (Tufts) D. Darsney de Salcedo (GW) J. Canahuati (Independent) P. Christian (JHBSPH)
12:25 PM	Way Forward & Closing Reflections	E. Keats (JHBSPH) S. Walton (JHBSPH) H. Tappis (Jhpiego)
12:45 PM	LUNCH	
1:45 PM	Day 2 / Meeting Adjourned	